

KRISHNA KUMAR, BJP



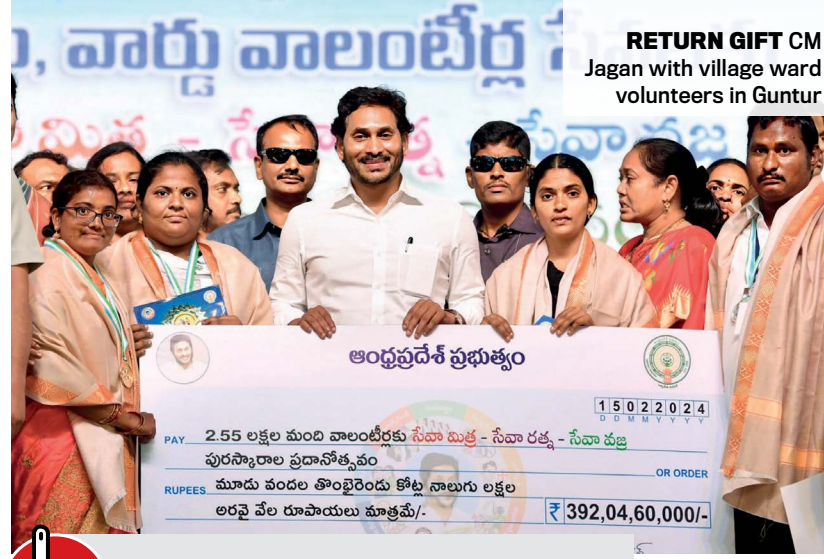
MUKESH CPI(M)

not work all the time. He's already got into a spot by referring to Thrissur's voters as his "subjects", which raised a few hackles among the very opinionated locals. But that is the least of his worries. In Muralee, he has one of the scrappiest Congress leaders in the state to deal with. The "Leader's son" is the sitting MP in Vadakara in

IN K. KARUNAKARAN'S SON MURALEE, SURESH GOPI HAS ONE OF THE SCRAPPIEST CONGRESS LEADERS IN THE STATE TO DEAL WITH

the north, but was brought to his late father's home base Thrissur especially for the task, and to defuse any ill-effects from the recent move of sister Padmaja to the BJP.

Meanwhile, the superstar is leaving nothing to chance, even attending Easter Mass with the Christian faithful, and breaking bread at a Ramadan feast. He has got the crowds, but will he get their votes? ■



RETURN GIFT CM Jagan with village ward volunteers in Guntur

MANDATE 2024 | ANDHRA PRADESH |

GROUND FLEET

Jagan side-steps EC fiat against his 'army' of ward and village volunteers, gets them to disburse pensions

By Amarnath S. Menon

On March 30, the Andhra Pradesh chief electoral officer Mukesh Kumar Meena put tough strictures on the Gram Sachivalayam and Ward Sachivalayam (GSWS) volunteers of the Jagan Reddy-led government. This follows the orders in February barring them from participating in any poll-related work.

The GSWS volunteers are, as Jagan himself describes it, the government's "brand ambassadors" in delivering the 38 welfare schemes it has launched that 'touch the lives of every citizen in the state'. The state government, though, seems to have circumvented the EC orders with its March 31 guidelines to disburse state pensions only through the village and ward-level secretariats till the elections are over and a new government is in place.

Over the past four years, the innovative GSWS village and ward secretariat system, set up to improve grassroots governance, has evolved to become the showcase achievement of the Jagan government. But, as expected, it has also raised apprehensions about the 266,000 GSWS volunteers transforming into foot soldiers of the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP). The suspicions have been fuelled by the "'intrusive manner" in which volunteers, be it in rural or urban areas, track the 50-100 households on their beat.

Many of these volunteers and facilitators—125,000 staff from various line departments—have emerged as the familiar face of the government for the people. The YSRCP is banking heavily on the slew of welfare measures implemented through GSWS to win a second term in the state—the elections for the 175-seat assembly and Lok Sabha (25 seats) are being held simultaneously on May 13. The 38 schemes together have some 127.4 million beneficiaries (many of them for multiple schemes).

Now, with the volunteers barred by the March 30 EC fiat, the state's department of rural development has circulated guidelines directing all village and ward level secretariat staff to carry out pension disbursement. Rivals led by the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) had already cried foul, alleging that the 'volunteers' are working as the eyes and ears of the YSRCP and collecting sensitive data that could be exploited for the elections. How will the EC now tackle the 'pension' move by the state? ■